

Is being on the AI team at my influential company making me complicit in creating more carbon emissions?

Posted by u/Difficult_Ad_2938 • 0 points • 3 comments

Idk where to ask this but I need advice.

I was moved on to my company's brand new AI team. It's a large and very influential company. So I'm not talking about individual usage of AI, I'm talking use on a large scale. I feel I have two options: try to work from within or leave the company.

I've been reading about the environmental impact of using AI. I know it's not AI itself making climate change worse, it's the data centers running on fossil fuels. I've got a lot of conflicting feelings about it all.

So help me figure this out: is it better to work toward making changes from within (I.e. attempt to track ai energy consumption so it helps us in our cost analysis) or is it better to leave the team as to not be complicit in using such an environmentally taxing tool? I know someone will take my spot and it will be used regardless, so it's a tough decision.

Comments

u/goodpairossocks • 1 points • 2025-01-02 18:06 UTC

Probably, the vast majority of all objects and activities in your daily life contribute more to carbon emissions than your work on AI ever will. If you are concerned about your personal contribution to carbon emission, it's probably much more effective to make changes elsewhere and keep your job.

E.g. use less plastic, don't eat food imported from across the ocean, don't fly, don't have children.

u/Difficult_Ad_2938 • 1 points • 2025-01-02 18:18 UTC

I will say, if I'm this worried about carbon emissions at my job, you can assume that I'm individually doing more than the average person to keep my personal emissions down.

However, this gets into the idea of personal vs. systemic contributions to climate change. My individual footprint is less of the issue when we should be focusing on large corporations causing

a majority of climate destruction. Which is where I'm at a loss. To me, it blurs the line between individual carbon footprint and the carbon footprint produced by big corporations.

I appreciate this comment because it is allowing me to flesh out my concerns further.

u/goodpairossocks • 1 points • 2025-01-02 18:33 UTC

>I appreciate this comment because it is allowing me to flesh out my concerns further.

I am positively surprised to find this attitude on Reddit. I thank you for elevating the civility and maturity of the discourse here.

>I know someone will take my spot and it will be used regardless, so it's a tough decision.

Sounds like you know what's the right thing to do, but a little devil on your shoulder is still whispering. I've been there, too. The best feeling in the world, in my opinion, is having respect for yourself because you did what you know was right, accepting the cost of having to do so.

From a different angle, the probability of you changing a business to do something that's better for the world rather than better for their quarterly numbers are approximately zero. I've been there, too. I've since quit working for large corporations.